

Stories of a Near Future

Foresight · Retreats · 4 days

A 4-day writing retreat where leadership teams draft the 2030 they would rather have — and stress-test it against evidence.

The three journeys

Narrative. You stopped forecasting and started writing. The 2030 you wrote is now a document your team can argue with.

Cognitive. Preferable-futures ontology: writing → evidence → back-cast → decision. Fiction as due diligence.

Identity. From strategist to storyteller-with-receipts.

Curriculum by module

Module 1 — Day 1 — Stakes

6h · Love — Why this matters

Outcome: First dispatches read.

Intent: Establish the emotional stakes of the future being written.

Prompt question: Whose 2030 are you writing? Whose are you not?

Exercise	Time	Prompt	Debrief
The Beneficiary List	20m	List 10 beneficiaries of your imagined 2030. Then 10 non-beneficiaries.	Ask: 'Which list did you write faster?'
First-Person Dispatch	45m	First-person 1-page dispatch from 2030, as a stakeholder — not you.	Read aloud. Only listen.
The Cost Question	15m	Every good future costs something. Write one paragraph: 'This future cost us ____'.	Debate as a group: 'Is that cost bearable?'

Artifact: A pile of dispatches from 2030.

Module 2 — Day 2 — Break

6h · Magic — The reframe

Outcome: Discontinuity integrated.

Intent: Break linear extrapolation with a discontinuity exercise.

Prompt question: What breaks between now and 2030 that you're not modelling?

Exercise	Time	Prompt	Debrief
Discontinuity Cards	30m	Draw a random discontinuity card. Rewrite your dispatch integrating it.	Ask: 'Which cards did the group refuse to draw twice?'
The Weird Signal	30m	Each person shares one weak signal from the last 6 months.	Cluster signals. Vote on which are most under-priced.
Time Slice	45m	Rewrite the same scene as 2027,	Ask: 'Which version scared you

		then 2033. Compare.	more?'
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Artifact: A wall of discontinuity cards and cluster of weak signals.

Module 3 — Day 3 morning — Back-cast

4h · Calm — Organize complexity

Outcome: Milestones + evidence + cost.

Intent: Introduce back-casting as the framework linking story to decision.

Prompt question: What would have to be true in 2027 for your 2030 to be true?

Exercise	Time	Prompt	Debrief
The Back-Cast	40m	Given your 2030 dispatch, list the 5 milestones of 2028, 2027, 2026.	Ask: 'Which milestone is missing from your current roadmap?'
Evidence Column	30m	Add one column: what evidence today makes each milestone plausible?	Circle the milestones with no evidence. Those are your bets.
The Cost Column	20m	Add one column: what must be stopped or shrunk?	Ask: 'Are you willing?'

Artifact: A back-cast sheet per team.

Module 4 — Day 3 afternoon — Court

4h · Open — Pattern discovery

Outcome: Story survives court.

Intent: Peer critique. Fiction as due diligence.

Prompt question: What holes did other people find in your future?

Exercise	Time	Prompt	Debrief
Story Court	60m	One team presents. Two teams cross-examine. One team defends.	Change roles every 30 min.
The Skeptic's Read	20m	Write a 1-paragraph skeptical review of another team's dispatch.	Give it to the author. Silent read.
Insurance Question	25m	List 5 risks and the price of insuring against each.	Ask: 'Which insurance can't you afford to skip?'

Artifact: A court transcript. A skeptical-review binder.

Module 5 — Day 4 — Decide

5h · Free — Commitment

Outcome: Decision cards + handoffs.

Intent: Turn the surviving story into a decision.

Prompt question: What one decision does this story now require?

Exercise	Time	Prompt	Debrief
The Story-to-Decision Bridge	30m	Write: 'If our 2030 is true, then before ____ we must decide ____.'	Read aloud. Notice repetition.
Bet Sizing	25m	For each decision: what's the	Publish the bet sizes.

		smallest bet that would test it?	
Story Handoff	10m	Name one person who needs this story before the quarter ends.	Schedule the handoff before leaving.

Artifact: A decision card. A bet-sizing sheet. A handoff appointment.

Commitment contract

What is the one decision your near-future story now requires?

If our 2030 is _____, then before _____ we must decide _____. The smallest bet that tests this is _____. The person who needs this story is _____.

Witness — The person you named for handoff.